



ON THE WRITE LINE

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Dead ball should not be part of referrals

Referrals should be only for dismissals given or not given, otherwise the **rhythm and flow** of the game will be upset considerably.

The ICC men's T20 World Cup has been of some ups and downs. While the ICC must be commended for bringing more Associate Member countries into the fold, it was clear that some were just not ready for the contests at this level. Teams getting bowled out under 50 and that score being chased down in under four overs tells of the vast gulf in the standards between the Full Member and the Associate Member teams.

On the other hand there is the story of USA, who not only beat the 2022 runners-up Pakistan but also gave India a tough time in their clash. The manner in which they chased down a near-200 score put up by Canada also showed that they were not fazed by the enormity of the event and had plenty of self belief. Yes, the USA side comprised mostly of expats from different parts of the world and not from those born in the USA, but that should not take anything away from their performance. They will be looking forward to the Super 8 part of the tournament where they get to play three other teams and show the world they are ready for sterner battles.

How can there be a World Cup and there isn't a controversy? That's the nature of any World Cup event in any sport. So there was the debate about the dead ball given in the match between South Africa and Bangladesh. The Bangladeshi batter Mahmudullah was given out LBW and the ball went off his leg-guards for a boundary. The batter asked for a review of the decision and the referral showed that he

was not out and the umpire thus had to reverse his earlier decision. However, since the batter was given out, the ball became dead and so while Mahmudullah survived, no leg byes were given to his team. The debate, therefore, was whether the four leg byes should have been credited or not. Eventually, Bangladesh lost by just four runs, so the debate only got heated. One must remember that as soon as the batter is given out the fielders relax and don't bother about the ball so the boundary fielders who otherwise would have tried to stop the ball would have rushed to celebrate the wicket than chase the ball. So the dead ball is the correct decision. If the margin of defeat wasn't four runs, then it wouldn't have mattered, but there you are.

Speaking of dead balls, I remember how when we were chasing the target of 438 set by England at The Oval in 1979 there were at least three occasions when a dead ball for not offering a stroke was called after we had taken three runs each time. I inquired of the umpire why was he making us run, on a hot day too, when he could have called a dead ball straightaway. He said because there was a chance of a run out. I countered by saying how could there be a dismissal if the ball was dead. He replied something to the effect that he doesn't make the rules but simply applies them. All those leg byes should have been given because there was no last second attempt on my part to leave the ball, but the umpire chose to think there was and in the end we were short of the target by eight runs.